



IT IS PERHAPS fitting that the two oldest IIMs, IIM Ahmedabad and IIM Calcutta, have come up tops by claiming first and second ranks, respectively, in the *BT-MDRA* India's Best B-Schools Survey in which 270 business schools participated. It was a close call: the difference between the two schools was just 0.6 points. The others in the Top Five are IIM Lucknow, SP Jain Institute of Management and Research and IIM Indore. In fact, there has been just a small reshuffle in the top ten pack. Further, in the top ten, the majority—six—are government-owned IIMs, while the other four are privately-owned and managed.

The ostensible lack of action at the top hides the varied undercurrents in India's B-school landscape captured by the *BT-MDRA* study. For one, B-school education continues to be in heavy demand as students look to encash its value as a ticket to a good corporate career. The average batch strength of top 100 B-schools rose from 1,076 in 2024 to 1,173 in 2025. "The demand for business education continues to grow steadily, and our numbers reflect this trend. For academic year 2025–26, 61,595 students applied to NMIMS, an increase from the previous year," says Papiya De, Program Chairperson, SVKM's Narsee Monjee Institute of Management Studies, Mumbai.

That said, the challenges remain, with global uncertainty, including trade wars, and fast adoption of technology such as AI, making companies wary of hiring. "On the placement front, we are aligned with global and national trends. The job market has remained muted over the past year, and like many B-schools, we have observed com-

panies reducing the number of internships offers. This is not a reflection on student quality but a broader hiring slowdown," says Papiya De.

The dip in placements is showing in salaries as well. The average salary at the Top 25 B-schools dipped from ₹23.12 lakh in 2023 to ₹22.7 lakh in 2025. Average salaries for graduates from the Top 25 B-schools have recorded the slowest growth (16%) in five years. This, along with a much larger fee increase, has lowered the return on investment of a B-school degree. The average course fee of Top 25 colleges rose from ₹18.78 lakh to ₹20.17 lakh. It has risen nearly 23% in the last five years.

Is this a blip? For some, yes. Despite the above challenges, McKinsey seems to be gung-ho about hiring India's B-school graduates; in the past three years, 77% of its hiring in India has been from leading B-schools. It has expanded the MBA summer hiring by 41% over the last two years. MBA graduates have long been an integral part of its talent pipeline. The firm says they bring in a wide variety of competencies: problem-solving acumen, leadership potential, and diverse professional experience along with analytical rigour, collaborative mindset, and global perspective.

Given the challenges of a world in flux, what practices are B-schools adopting to thrive and make a mark?

ONE MBA

The demand for a good management education encouraged many B-schools such as NMIMS, IIMA, Great Lakes Institute and SP Jain to open multiple campuses. But they often struggle to tap the full synergies between them. The School of Management, NMIMS, is out to change that. It has made its flagship MBA programme into an integrated offering designed to give students across campuses a seamless experience. Its 'One MBA' initiative is more than a shared syllabus. It is a structured system in which faculty members from every campus come together to jointly design, deliver, and evaluate the course. The initiative is anchored by the Mumbai campus, which hosts weekly faculty meetings and collaborative workshops where course plans, teaching approaches, evaluation methods, and even classroom experiences are aligned. As a result, not only is the curriculum common, but so are the